

The Moura's Lost Comb

In the enchanted springs of Portugal, cobblestone towns sit among terracotta roofs, almond trees that blossom white as snow, and hills crowned with stars. Water is the magic here: every spring, fountain, and old stone well has its own quiet wonder. Enchanted maidens called the Mouras keep the springs sweet, a bright rooster crows only the truth, and a playful little goblin called the Trasgo tidies and teases when no one is looking. Here a hero wins not by being the strongest, but by being kind, asking the water gently, and never giving up on a friend. Even a big, fearsome-looking giant of the hills usually turns out to be lonelier than it is frightening.

The answers are here. This part is for the grown-up, not for the child.

Show the matching picture in the Atlas as you reach each place.



Read aloud, slowly and warmly. Stop often to let the children answer. There are no wrong answers here, only new ideas to try.

Before you begin

This morning the village square is full of worried voices. The Old Fountain has gone quiet. Its water sits still and grey, and nobody can fill their jugs.

You stand at the edge of the square. An old woman says, "The fountain is fed by the Enchanted Spring, up in the hills. Something has gone wrong up there. Will you go and see?"

You pick up your bag. You look at each other and nod. The path winds up into the green hills.



What is your hero name? Which magics do you choose: Bloom, Truth, Starlight, or Riversong?

Stop 1 The Quiet Spring

You climb until you reach a clear spring among mossy stones. Beside it sits a gentle maiden with long dark hair. This is the Moura Encantada. She looks sad and a little shy.

"My golden comb is gone," she says softly. "Without it I cannot wake the water, and the fountain in your village stays quiet. But I am too shy to go looking."

She will only talk to a calm, kind voice.



How do you put her at ease? Could you speak gently to the spring with Riversong? What kind thing could you say or do?

When the Moura trusts you, she smiles. "A shiny trail leads off into the ferns," she says. "Follow it, and please be gentle with whoever you find."

Stop 2 The Stepping Stones

The trail leads to a shallow stream. To cross it you must step on the right stones. Each stone has a small carved mark: a leaf, a star, a wave, then a leaf, a star, and a gap where the next mark should be.

A little voice in the water hums, "Leaf, star, wave, leaf, star, and then?"



What mark comes next in the pattern? Which stone do you step on?

When you step on the wave stone, the water steadies and lets you across. On the far bank, the shiny trail leads under a little stone bridge.

Stop 3 The Trasgo's Nook

Under the bridge is a cosy nook full of bright, shiny things. In the middle sits a small goblin in a red cap, the Trasgo, playing happily with the golden comb. He grins at you.

"I found it. It is shiny. It is mine now," he says, holding it tight. He is not mean. He just loves shiny things and a good game, and he is a little lonely down here.



How do you make friends with the Trasgo? Could you offer a swap, a riddle, or a game? What would a playful goblin like?

When you trade something he loves, or win his game, the Trasgo laughs and hands over the comb. "Come and visit me again," he says. "It is quiet under here."

Stop 4

The Comb Returned

You carry the golden comb back up to the spring. The Moura Encantada is waiting. Very carefully, you place the comb in her hands.

She draws it once through her long hair. The water lights up clear and bright and lifts in a gentle, glowing arc.



How do you give the comb back kindly? What do you say to the Moura?

"Thank you," she says. "You were gentle, and you made a friend instead of an enemy. The water will sing again."

The Spring Sings Again

You hurry back down to the village. The Old Fountain is bubbling clear and bright, and the water almost sings. Children laugh and fill their jugs. The Moura sends a cool, sweet blessing down with the water.

You did it together. You were kind, and you were full of ideas. Well done.

The Moura's Lost Comb: Rules for the Grown-Up

The Guide for the Grown-Up explains how the game works (the difficulty bands, the energy stars, helping, twists, all of it). This page has only what is special about this adventure. A failed roll is never a defeat; nobody loses.

Setting up

- Print the map, or sketch it, or lay it out with household objects: a Start, four stops, and a Goal on a winding path. Each player puts a small figure (a building-brick minifigure works well) on the Start.
- Each player chooses three magics from the four in this world: Bloom, Truth, Starlight, and Riversong. A mix across the players works best, because combining magics is half the fun.
- Give each player five energy stars (five small tokens or bricks). These are spent and refilled during play.
- Build the things that come up (the golden comb, the stepping stones, the Trasgo's shiny hoard) from household bits and bricks as you go. Anything can be anything.
- Keep your dice and the dice-band table from the back of the kit beside you.

The surprise

Once at each stop the players may roll for a twist; read the matching line. The Guide explains how it works.

Roll	Surprise
1	The Galo de Barcelos crows nearby and points you to one free hint.
2	You find a glint of water-light: take back one energy star.
3	A kind breeze off the hills: the next challenge is Easy.
4	The Moura hums a few notes of her water-song. All is well; carry on.
5	A friendly creature lets you repeat one roll later, whenever you like.
6	Almond blossom drifts past and everyone smiles for one happy turn.

How it ends

The golden comb is not won in a battle. The Trasgo, who has it, is not a villain: he is a playful, lonely goblin who only wanted a shiny treasure and someone to play with. The adventure turns on befriending him, not beating him, and on being gentle with the shy Moura Encantada. Let both of those land softly; that kindness is the whole point. See the puzzles page for how to play each stop, and for the solutions.

The Moura's Lost Comb: Puzzles and Solutions

For your eyes, not the children's. Each stop lists its band, what the players need to work out, the intended solution, and a gentle fallback so a stuck child always moves forward. More than one good idea should work; reward good ideas and kindness over the "right" answer.

Stop 1: The Quiet Spring (Easy)

The challenge. The Moura Encantada has lost her golden comb and is too shy to say much. She will only point the way once the players have earned her trust with calm, gentle kindness.

Intended solutions. This is a social, gentle-heart moment more than a magic trick:

- **Riversong** is the natural fit: speak softly to the spring, and let the water carry a kind word to the Moura.
- **Bloom** can soften the mood, coaxing a few flowers up at the water's edge as a small gift.
- A simple kind action with no magic at all (sitting quietly, speaking gently, promising to help) works just as well.

Fallback. If the children are unsure what to say, have the Moura ask a tiny question of her own ("Have you come from the village? Is the fountain very sad without its water?") to give them a thread to pull. Any genuine kindness opens her up and tops up an energy star.

Make it simpler. For a younger child, just have everyone say one kind thing to the Moura, or wave hello gently, and let that be enough for her to smile and point to the trail.

Stop 2: The Stepping Stones (Normal)

The challenge. A line of carved stepping stones crosses a stream. The marks run leaf, star, wave, leaf, star, and then a crumbled stone. The players must work out which mark belongs on the missing stone and step on that one.

Solution. The pattern repeats in threes: **leaf, star, wave, leaf, star, wave**. So the missing mark is the **wave**, and the wave stone is the safe step. Logic and observation do the work here, not a magic, though **Riversong** can ask the stream to confirm, and **Starlight** can light the carvings if the day is dim.

Fallback. If the children are stuck, read the watery rhyme again slowly, tapping each stone in turn so they hear the three-beat pattern. Working it out with help still counts as a full success and tops up an energy star.

Make it simpler. For a younger child, lay out just three objects (leaf, star, wave) and then leaf, star again, and ask only "what comes next?"

Stop 3: The Trasgo's Nook (Normal)

The challenge. The Trasgo has the golden comb and loves it because it is shiny. He will not give it up to scolding or grabbing. He is playful and lonely, and he wants a game, a riddle, or a fair swap.

Intended solutions. This is a befriending moment:

- **A fair swap.** Offer him something he would love as much: a shiny carried object, a chip of mirror, a slice of rosca bread (he cannot resist its smell).
- **A riddle or a game.** Trade riddles, or play a quick game; win it, or simply play along generously, and he hands the comb over for the fun of it.
- **Truth** can gently show him the comb belongs to the Moura and the village needs it, and that a friend is better than a treasure. **Bloom** can brighten his lonely nook so he feels less alone.

Fallback. If the children freeze, have the Trasgo propose the game himself ("I will trade it for a good riddle. Got one?") so there is an obvious door to walk through. The moment they make any friendly offer, let him laugh and give up the comb.

Make it simpler. For a younger child, let a single shiny swap or one shared joke be enough; the Trasgo is easily delighted.

Stop 4: The Comb Returned (Easy)

The challenge. The players carry the comb back and return it to the Moura Encantada. The only "test" is to do it gently and kindly, so the moment stays warm.

Intended solution. Have the players hand the comb over with care and say something kind. There is no roll to fail here. **Riversong** can let them tell the spring the good news first; any gentle gesture completes it.

Fallback. If a child is shy, the Moura simply reaches out and takes the comb with thanks. The success is guaranteed; this stop is about the warm feeling, not a puzzle.

Make it simpler. For a younger child, just placing the comb in the Moura's hands and watching the water light up is the whole of it.

The Spring Sings Again (no roll)

This is the resolution, not a puzzle, so there is no band and no roll. The Moura draws the comb through her hair, the spring wakes, and down in the square the Old Fountain runs clear and sings again. Let the children feel the whole village's relief and the Moura's cool, sweet blessing. They won by being gentle with a shy spirit and making a friend of the Trasgo instead of an enemy, which is the only way anyone wins among the Enchanted Springs.

Wander and Tales

Tale Book

<https://github.com/agigante80/wander-and-tales>

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Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.